

Family Trait

Old wine served in a new bottle
but vintage Bond never ages



BOOK OF HUMOUR
by RUSKIN BOND
Penguin
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 278

■ By Dilip Bobb

Recycling is a politically correct thing to do, except for publishers looking to improve their bottom lines. Ruskin Bond, like Khushwant Singh, is always a good bet for the silly season when his earlier stories can be repackaged and marketed to unsuspecting buyers. This collection has just two short stories that have not been published before; the other 27 are culled from earlier books. That may be a bit of a literary con but it's an accepted practice in the publishing business. The other con is more serious, pun intended. This is meant to be a book of humour when there's actually very little of it in this anthology.

Basically, these are short stories about the author's relatives and extended family, always a rich source of literary material, and animals and pets, familiar to Bond's readers. There are humorous situations but Bond is no humorist. He is a simple man with simple tastes and a simple, effortless style of writing that has universal appeal. If there is humour in his writing, it comes from the characters or the situations they find themselves in, not as a deliberate literary genre.

In that context, this is vintage Bond, even if much of the content has been published before. There's the eccentric Uncle Ben who features again in one of the two new stories, and others like Uncle Bill and Aunt Ruby and acquaintances in Mussoorie where he lives. As the author points out, "everyone has at least one aunt or uncle who is a potential nutcase. I had several. Thanks to them, I have never run out of stories." This anthology would have benefited from more original stories but even so, authors like Bond have that rare gift of producing stories that, like good quality wine, seem to improve with age. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (12)	The Appeal	John Grisham	Random House
2. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
3. (2)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Penguin
4. (3)	Shantaram	Gregory Roberts	Little Brown
5. (15)	The Japanese Wife	Kunal Basu	HarperCollins

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (4)	We Are Like That Only: Understanding the Logic of Consumer India	Rama Bijapurkar	Penguin
3. (3)	Monk Who Sold His Ferrari	Robin Sharma	Jaico Books
4. (11)	Why Mars and Venus Collide	John Gray	HarperCollins
5. (6)	Maximum City: Bombay Lost And Found	Suketu Mehta	Penguin

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
8. (-)	One Night@The Call Centre	Chetan Bhagat	Rupa & Co
9. (6)	Chowringhee	Shankar	Penguin
12. (13)	The Age of Shiva	Manil Suri	Bloomsbury

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
13. (17)	India After Gandhi: The History of the World's Largest Democracy	Ramchandra Guha	Picador
14. (7)	The Elephant, The Tiger & Cellphone	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin
16. (-)	The Kao Boys of R&AW	B. Raman	Lancer
18. (-)	What The Customer Wants You To Know	Ram Charan	Penguin

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead